

ASSABIAN RITES

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Sorcerous Lore, Spells and Skills for the Thennla Campaign Setting

Part One: Assabian Sorcery

This is the first of a series of articles that describe how Mythras sorcery works in the most sorcerous region of the magic-rich world setting of Thennla. I hope they provide some fuel for sorcery-oriented characters and adventures in the setting – but also provide some inspiration for those looking for ways add some unique flavour to Mythras sorcery for their own homebrew campaign worlds.

To get the most from these articles you will need access to the Mythras Core Rules. There are also a few basic assumptions about how rules apply in the setting that are useful to know. You can find these in Shores of Korantia, but they are also in the free Thennla PDF you can get from Drivethru RPG. Questions like Magic Point Recovery rates, and descriptions of the three Sorcery Lores, are all set out there.

One thing to bear in mind is that the setting puts limits on ‘natural’ human abilities. Skills cannot exceed a character’s basic percentage x 5%. Characteristics scores are capped at 21, and in both cases only magical intervention can allow a character to exceed the limitations of the human frame. This should always come at a cost – physical, psychological and/or moral. There is a reason that Zygas Taga, the Taskan Emperor, is hidden away from public gaze it in

the confines of his palace at Taskay...he has become a *monster*.

These articles will be putting forward many add-ons for Mythras including new spells, skills and passions. These are usually adaptations of setting material that may have been originally laid out using the RQ3 (Avalon Hill) framework and evolved further under Legend and RQ6. Over recent years I have moved away from working up homebrewed alternative rules to reflect the setting as you would have found in the Legend version (Age of Treason), and towards attempting to achieve creative objectives using the RAW (Rules As Written) wherever possible. Mythras is a fantastic game system to begin with, and with such riches on



hand it doesn't do credit to Loz and Pete's creation to add more rules unnecessarily. Of course, I am going to anyway...but hopefully in a way that fits neatly into the existing framework.

This first article introduces the role of the sorcerer – and sorcerous thinking – in Assabia. It covers the role of Grimoires, the foundation stones of sorcery traditions; familiars and how to create one; details the three key philosophies, or *Passions*, of Assabian sorcery; and outlines the common types of Cults and Brotherhoods encountered in the region.

Sorcery In Assabia

Magic is a technology, and like any technology there will be people looking to exploit it to their advantage. You could say that Sorcery is characterised by selfish and self-seeking forms of exploitation, compared to Theism in which magic is typically harnessed to the advantage of a wider community. While there's some truth to that, it's far too neat a distinction, especially in the Holy City of Djesmir, which is right at the heart of the magical traditions described here. Minor deities, ethereal entities, demons and more are routinely approached through sorcerous arts and deals struck to mutual advantage.

Members of a Sultan's family (and sometimes even the ruler himself) might dabble in sorcery, and each Sultan maintains a retinue of skilled sorcerers to advise him on magical matters, protect him from magical attack and provide magical wonders to serve as amusements at court. But a professional sorcerer can never become Sultan. Using magic to claim political power is by tradition and general consensus

the most dangerous and heinous means to do so. Members of the royal houses of Djesmirket and Morkesh who devote significant time to learning sorcery (in game terms, having the Shaping skill) must step aside from any claim to the throne. This extends to a general prohibition on appointment of sorcerers to positions as Bey (regional governor) or Uprama (local lord). Some sorcerers are promoted to the role of Vizier, frequently wielding power second only to the Sultan. However those holding lofty positions with access to the rulers are a very small subset of the Assabian sorcery industry. For many, sorcery is no more than a trade with which to earn a living. There are a great many magicians of every stamp, from bookish students to philosopher-magicians, swaggering spell-slingers for hire, spell-collectors, corrupted demonists and 'Spell Slaves'.

There are many different magical pathways for the sorcerer to explore. Most are harmless enough, and contribute to the sum of mankind's knowledge as well as providing genuinely useful tools and enhancements that benefit society at large. But some can be highly dangerous, or involve very questionable practices that can erode a sorcerer's humanity and imperil his soul. Making Pacts with otherworld entities is a well-known feature of Assabian sorcery, but it comes at a price and potentially at some risk, not just to the sorcerer but also to those around him. Those sorcerers whose work puts them beyond the pale might retreat to some out of the way place where they can carry on their anti-social business in private, but in the Sultanate of Jelhai they may find official welcome and sponsorship.

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Sorcerous Traditions and Grimoires

The root of any sorcery tradition is a Grimoire. This is a carefully curated collection of sorcery spells, typically but not always in the form of a book, sometimes with important additional information included such as alchemical formulae, or a bestiary of otherworld creatures a sorcerer can conjure with. Each Grimoire is uniquely styled and formulated and requires its own unique Invocation skill to cast its magic, although the Shaping skill is common to all. Djesmiri is the most common script in which sorcerous books and treatises are written. Writing magic requires a high style filled with antiquated vocabulary and obscure symbols, helping the magical arts to remain the preserve of the highly literate. A few magical works are written in Morkeshite, and in recent times sorcery developed within the Taskan Empire uses Tarsenian, the language of the Empire's homeland. Assabians are generally horrified that copies of magical texts should be kept at the Empire's public libraries. Making the wonders of sorcery broadly available in this way is both vulgar and very bad for business.

To make the contents of a Grimoire more widely accessible, copies can be made. Sometimes the original is subsequently broken

up, lost or destroyed, and so these copies become the only means by which the tradition is preserved. Some traditions are only known from incomplete spell books, or even single sheets or fragments.

However whenever a Grimoire is copied there is a chance for errors to creep in which make the copies less useful to learn from. Good first-generation copies made from a Grimoire enable a sorcerer to learn a new spell simply by spending time and expending the required experience rolls as if they had access to the Grimoire itself. They may not contain all the spells of the master text. Copies may fall short in many other ways: corrupted text, missing pages; mistranslations and interpolations.

Incomplete manuscripts make it harder to learn the spells they purport to offer. The Games Master may represent this simply by requiring additional Improvement Rolls as the Character works out how to fill the gaps in the text, or the Character may have to quest to find the missing text. Otherwise if a copy is faulty due to an omission or error in the text then there is an increased chance any casting roll will fail, or a much-increased chance of a Fumble or Mishap. The caster may be unaware of the problem until they try to use the spell they have learned.

Faulty Spell Table		
D20 roll	Effect	Details
01-03	Highly Volatile	Any successful casting roll will result in a Mishap in addition to the spell taking effect as normal
04-06	Very Risky	Any casting failure will result in a Mishap
07-09	Touch and Go	Any casting failure is treated as a Fumble (i.e. Magic Points are expended but to no effect). Any Fumble will result in a Mishap.
10-12	Disappointing	The casting roll is downgraded, so a Critical becomes a Normal Success and a Normal Success becomes a failure. Any Resistance Roll against the spell is automatically one grade easier
13-15	Exasperating	Only a Critical Success will succeed in casting the spell, although Critical Effects still apply
16-18	Nerfed	Intensity halved; all manipulations reduced to 1 point of Shaping
96-00	Messy	Roll twice and apply both results

Some example spellcasting Mishaps include:

- An additional, randomly chosen target is inadvertently affected by the spell
- In the event of a failed casting roll, an alternative target is affected as if the spell succeeded
- The Magic Point cost of the spell is automatically doubled.

A sorcerer can create a new Grimoire using a special enchantment spell: Write Magic.

WRITE MAGIC

Charm, Concentration, Ritual

A sorcerer can use this enchantment to create a new Grimoire, in which he collates the knowledge of spells that he selects from those he has learned from diverse sources into a single new 'tradition' covered by the same Invocation skill.

The Sorcerer invests Characteristic INT in the creation of the Grimoire, granting the Grimoire itself an artificial 'Golem' INT. This is rolled according to the Golem Characteristics table. The Grimoire's INT is the maximum number of spells it can contain. In addition, the Grimoire's INT is added to the Sorcerer's both to determine his Basic Percentage in Invoking magic from the Grimoire and the maximum Invocation skill he can achieve (Aptitude).

Golem Characteristic Table	
<i>Intensity</i>	<i>Golem Characteristic Gain per Point Invested</i>
1-3	1d3
4-6	1d4
7-9	1d6
10-12	1d8
13+	1d10

All the necessary instructions for the casting must be inscribed on whatever is being used as the Grimoire over a number of Task Rounds

using the Literacy skill. The duration of each Task Round is typically a day per spell to be inscribed.

It is not necessary to inscribe all the desired spells at once, as the sorcerer can drop the spell's concentration to deal with other tasks and physical needs. However once work on the Grimoire has begun it must be completed within the spell's Duration. Write Magic is a Charm, which uses the longer Durations provided in the settings books for temporary enchantments. The Sorcerer's player should state in what order he intends to inscribe the spells in the Grimoire. If the task takes too long and the Write Magic spell ends, then the resulting work will be incomplete in like proportion.

The Sorcerer may add to the Grimoire at a later date by staging the enchantment again, so long as it has unused INT. In this case any fumbled skill roll will unpick the work that has been done before rendering the Grimoire useless. He may not make a further sacrifice to increase the INT of the Grimoire once this is set.

Each spell can still be used by the sorcerer at the skill relating to the Grimoire he has copied them from; however once the new Grimoire has been created the Sorcerer gains a new Grimoire skill, applicable to all the spells within it. The Sorcerer gains this as a starting skill in the new Invocation (Grimoire) equal to his own INT x 2 plus the INT of the book.

The sorcerer does not need to have the book on his person to cast spells from it. However so long as the Grimoire is within the Range of the original Write Magic spell with which it was created, casting rolls are always one grade easier. If a sorcerer is worried that his grimoire is too precious to keep about his person, it can be locked away behind magical wards, but ready to be brought to the owner's hand using the Mark spell combined with Summon.

The destruction of a master copy Grimoire immediately inflicts damage on the creator and can be fatal. 1D6 damage is inflicted directly to the sorcerer's head per point of INT invested in the book; he will temporarily lose INT equal to the INT of the book (Willpower test for half damage but if this roll is fumbled the loss is permanent), regained at a rate of one point per successful Endurance roll, test once per day of complete rest. Should this disaster reduce the Sorcerer's INT below 0, she is dead.



A Grimoire need not be a book; there are sorcerers who think the safest thing is to inscribe their spells on their bodies rather than in an inanimate object – their tattooed skin becomes the spell book. While being a handy way to ensure the book is always within range, it also provides some security.

A sorcerer who creates a Grimoire usually wins significant respect among his peers; the sorcerer can now instruct others in the Invocation skill associated with the new Grimoire. If the Grimoire subsequently falls

into the wrong hands or copies are made, its contents can be studied and learned by others.

Familiars

Sorcerers often have familiars to help them with their work. The necessary enchantment is relatively common among sorcery Grimoires. There are significant advantages in having a familiar, and being seen with one is a way of displaying one's sorcery credentials. But it can come at some risk as well.

CREATE FAMILIAR

Resist (Willpower), Ritual

An enchantment spell typically used on natural creatures, which requires that the sorcerer bestows the prospective familiar with one point of INT of his own, converting its INS to INT; and a minimum of 1 point of CHA. The familiar now has a Golem CHA of its own determined using the Golem Characteristic table above.

With its new-found INT the creature becomes capable of rational thought and with its new CHA the creature becomes capable of meaningful interaction with other rational creatures. Familiar and Sorcerer are mentally and emotionally linked so long as the familiar and sorcerer are within the Range of the spell from one another. The familiar completely empathises with its master and is able to communicate telepathically with him. If either sorcerer or familiar fumble a Willpower role when resisting a magical attack, the other must succeed in a resistance role or also be affected.

The sorcerer may use the familiar's Magic Points so long as he is within the spell's range, but may not reduce them below species minimum POW. Sometimes the most powerful familiars are harder to exploit in this way.

The familiar gains an Obedience (Master) Passion equal to 30+INT+CHA but is quite

capable of acquiring other passions that are less convenient for the enchanter. The familiar can also learn new skills including magical skills in its own right, however if not humanoid in form the familiar is limited to Folk Magic spells and cannot use sorcery.

If the familiar is killed, then the sorcerer will suffer deep psychological and physical shock. The Games Master can refer to the Diseases and Poisons table in Mythras core rules for some useful ideas of possible effects. Nevertheless the sorcerer will gradually recover the Characteristic Points invested in the familiar at their Healing rate per month.

Passions: The Philosophies of Sorcery

Many people right across Assabia take a keen interest in debating the finer points of where magic comes from, what are the most important magical arts, the power of its practitioners, and what magic is actually for. Out of this intense interest in the arcane come three core philosophies, and many people align themselves with one or another of them.

Each of these philosophies may be chosen as a Passion at 30%+ INT+POW, and used to augment skill rolls in the right circumstances like any other Passion.

Theurgism

Theurgist call upon supernatural beings to empower the sorcerer to achieve what he wants. Many of them are devoutly religious and regard their magical practices as an extension of their religious studies. Theurgists have been known to step in and maintain some holy place or shrine that is fallen into disuse, its devotees and cultists moved on or dwindled away. They may also attempt to join a cult, or to recreate religious rites long forgotten, in order to access divine powers.

A Theurgist might indeed be proud to proclaim herself '[name], slave of the God (x)'. There is a divine order to be respected, and gods worthy of worship who can bestow gifts, knowledge and favours upon their followers. Many sorcerers are devotees of one or more deity, and some are also priests. In a Theurgist's view, man only should only dare tread into the supernatural realm once armed with the right permissions, guides and supernatural protection.

Most in fact subscribe to the more venal Assabian approach to religion where dealing with Gods, like any supernatural entity, is a matter of striking a mutually beneficial deal between man and deity. The character and intentions of the deity in question – whether benevolent or malevolent - may not be front of mind in such negotiations, only the advantage to be gained.

Theurgists believe that the nature of Man is distinct from that of Spirits, Ethereals, Demons and Gods. The mundane world and all life native to it is magically inert. Only the intrusion of the supernatural changes that. So it follows that Man cannot generate magic of himself, but either knowingly or unknowingly forges links with otherworld beings, tapping into their magical natures.

Theurgism is an ancient and very traditionalist view of the world. The chief area of research is to establish a taxonomy of supernatural beings, profiling each one to determine the best way to earn favour from the greater and control the lesser. The top of the supernatural hierarchy is occupied by the major gods and goddesses of Djesmir, deities of the 'First Circle'. The First Circle includes deities such as Shomat, Haliset and Tolat, and Urunki the weather god, who are only accessible through theistic cults. The Second Circle is made up of many lesser deities such as Basat, Talok, Temmush, and Shara Peshwan, patron

goddess of Sharranket. Gods and Goddesses of the Second Circle are usually beyond the reach of sorcery, but there are exceptions. The Third Circle is of lesser deities again who may receive no formal worship or else the cults that honour them are rather small. The offerings of an ambitious sorcerer may be tempting enough for such a deity to investigate further.

After the gods come Ethereals and Demons, then the 'incomplete' Spirits and Elementals, and finally the 'inert' – humankind and other sentient, non-magical life forms.

Theurgism is at the heart of the art of Conjuration. A Conjuror is someone skilled in evoking supernatural beings including those normally resident in other realities, and causing them to appear to mortals in the mundane world. Certain specialist versions of the Evoke spell are unique to magical traditions inspired by Theurgism.

Materialism

Theurgists are the antithesis of Materialists. Materialism has a long history in Djesmirket, stretching back over 500 years, and even those who don't subscribe to this way of thinking are in some way influenced by it. Materialists are often referred to as Atheists. But Materialism doesn't deny the existence of gods (which would be absurd) but denies the necessity to worship them. Some Materialists do believe worship of the gods should actually be outlawed, but most are content to regard it as a practice that will in time naturally become unnecessary and obsolete because human command of magic will one day outstrip whatever supernatural intervention gods have to offer.

Materialists have a reputation for being dismissive and condescending towards the religious. The phrase '[name], Slave of the God (x)' is a form frequently used to refer to those who are devotees of one or more deities, and

as spoken by a Materialist is deliberately condescending.

Materialists believe the power to control nature in a god-like way lies in perfecting their understanding of nature itself. This includes the idea that new Natures beyond Fire, Water, Stone, Air and Flesh are there to be discovered, described and harnessed. These may be reflected in the mundane world but not native to it; Light and Darkness are often cited as an example, but current theory postulates a total of 17 'non-mundane' natures. The quest to identify and harness these elements is the defining ambition of materialist research.

Materialism is at the heart of Alchemy, Artifice and Enchantment. The Artificers of Sorandib have their origin in an order of materialist sorcerers originally based in Morkesh.

Dimensionalism

This school of thought evolved over the last 300 years and for a period enjoyed significant popularity. It still does in Morkesh whose people claim to have originated it. The philosophy is rooted in the exploration of alternative dimensions both within and beyond the Three Realities. Ethereal entities – that seem to ignore the constraints of existence in the mundane world - are their main obsession.

Dimensionalists obsess endlessly about things which simultaneously both 'are' and 'are not', are both 'present' and 'absent'. Classic dimensionalist magic includes feats such as invisibility and being in more than one place at one time. Some dimensionalists search for the means to metamorphose themselves into Ifrit as a stepping-stone to acquiring freedom to move across the dimensions.

Magic for a dimensionalist does not derive from the innate powers of any entity such as a god, but an essence of nature that some

entities are better able to harness than others. Man is at the lower end of the scale compared to ifrit, gods and many demons – but nevertheless can learn to be like them. This essence is, at least for now, beyond comprehension as it can only be glimpsed incompletely from each of the Three Realities. This essence is harnessed by creatures and entities of each of the three realities in different ways and subject to different limitations. The ultimate outcome, should anyone succeed, is godhood. Dimensionalists pay close attention to the progress of the Taskan Emperor Zygas Taga towards his apotheosis.

The following spells are only available from Grimoires which spring from Dimensionalist philosophy:



Bypass Armour, Portal, Summon, Teleport

Sorcery Cults and Brotherhoods

Both Cults and Brotherhoods exist across Assabia that welcome or require its members to practice the sorcerous arts. Joining a cult or brotherhood is not the only way to learn sorcery, but some organisations keep close control over Grimoires, magical artefacts, exclusive Pacts with magical beings and other resources that an ambitious sorcerer may crave access to.

Colleges

Also known as Academies, these are places where you can join with like-minded souls to study magical Lore under the direction of a well-respected teacher. Academies are not open to just anyone. A prospective student is expected to demonstrate a passion for philosophy in line with the teacher, and pay a joining fee as well as a quarterly or biannual membership charge thereafter. The fees go towards running costs and lining the teacher's pocket. Colleges can meet in all kinds of places – public plazas, private gardens – very rarely in specially constructed libraries and meeting halls. As they are centred on a particular teacher rather than being institutions, colleges don't tend to last for more than a generation. An Exception is the Academy of Infinite Determination in Largil, which has been in existence for 90 years and had four different chief professors. College lecturers do not normally provide training in Invocation or Shaping, nor provide knowledge of specific spells to students, but may do so for staff.

Guilds

Sorcery is not a profession in itself, but guilds exist around specific trades that require the practitioners to be sorcerers. They can provide their members with training and some guilds may offer members with financial help in hard times, take care of funeral costs and provide a

small pension to surviving dependents. But their purpose is mostly ensuring minimum professional standards, enforcing a closed shop for their members, and settling disputes between them. Of course all guilds serve as a network through which members may offer each other informal support. The Guild of Necromantic Advocacy is well known (although its branch in Jelhai has become a separate splinter organisation), as is the Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir, which actually has members in cities across Djesmirket and Morkesh and has an immensely important branch in Shimir because of the unique materials that can be sourced via Sharranketan trade routes.

Pacting Cults

These are cults that are run by, rather than for, sorcerers. In the shadows of the ancient temples to the First Circle gods, the streets of Djesmir are full of proselytising sorcerers, street shrines, dark alleys leading to back-room meeting places, where the business of Pacting is conducted. Sorcerers who have done a deal (made a Pact) with some supernatural being might sell the same access to others, and in the process a sort of cult is formed. The most ambitious of these cults bring together a set of different entities, each accessible to members as they pass through new stages of initiation. The cult leader no doubt ensures the Boon(s) he has gained are greater than those to be bestowed on recruits, or will be magnified as more conversions are made. The rules and rituals are more often geared towards satisfying mummery, that pleases the punters and helps them part with their cash and magic points, then any kind of spiritual values. Members – few of whom will be sorcerers themselves - may number in single digits or up to several dozen, and is often very fickle, driven by fashion, desperation or ennui. Now and again one of these micro cults really takes off and become something of a craze. When that happens there may be a crackdown.

Sorcery Orders

The most elaborate brotherhoods are the Courts. These organisations admit only sorcerers to their membership, but may employ non-sorcerers as staff. Some are broad enough in outlook to admit sorcerers of different philosophical persuasions, and practitioners of different trades. The leadership must appear to be disinterested in worldly affairs and certainly above getting themselves involved in politics, although there is no shortage of rumour about intrigues involving one or more of the Courts getting involved in the power struggles between different guilds, noble families and of course, each other.

There are only a handful of these orders: One in Sharranket (The Court of the Ways based at Homora), another in Morkesh (The Court of Signs based in Morkar); one, the famous Court of Colours, native to Djesmir. Two others – The Court of Letters headquartered in Khorala and The Court of Harmonies, formerly headquartered in Ankwar but latterly exiled to Perlak, are active across the whole region.

Each Court has its own rules for admission – usually restricted to those who have already completed apprenticeship with an existing member - and its own internal ranks and hierarchy. Members are able to access training and resources such as Grimoires held by the order in line with their rank. The Court of Letters runs a business in selecting and training spell-slaves for the market.

Coming Up Next...

Part Two of Assabian Rites will look more closely at the professions available to sorcerers, and some of the specialist magic and skills that different trades have developed over the centuries.